

Kill Switch Governance

The Art of Subtraction.

A fiduciary framework for identifying and deleting revenue-negative code to restore engineering velocity.

Richard Ewing | The Product Economist

Your Product is Bloated. Your Margins are Bleeding.

80%

Revenue from 20% of Codebase

In the average Enterprise SaaS, the vast majority of revenue comes from a tiny fraction of features.

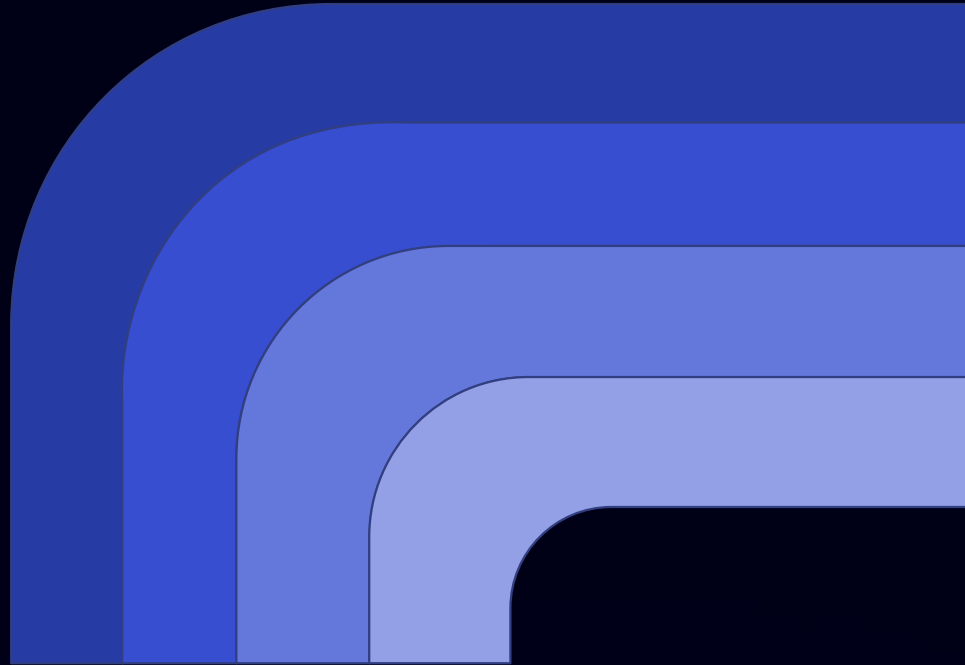
80%

Zombie Code

The remaining codebase generates **Zero Revenue** while consuming resources.

The Cost: You are paying Cloud costs, Security Compliance costs, and "Cognitive Load" taxes on features that generate **Zero Revenue**. This is not "Technical Debt." It is Financial Waste.

Why We Don't Delete.



Past Investment Anchor

Sunk Cost Drag

Forward Costs

Future Opportunities

The Trap

"But we spent \$500k building it!"

The Rebuttal

That money is gone. The only relevant number is the **Forward-Looking Carrying Cost.**

❏ **The Maxim:** "A feature that does not pay its own rent (Server + Support Costs) must be evicted."

How to Calculate the "Zombie Score."

A feature is designated "**Distressed Asset**" if:

1

Usage

Used by < 5% of Total Active Users (TAU).

2

Revenue

Cannot be directly attributed to Retention or Upsell.

3

Maintenance

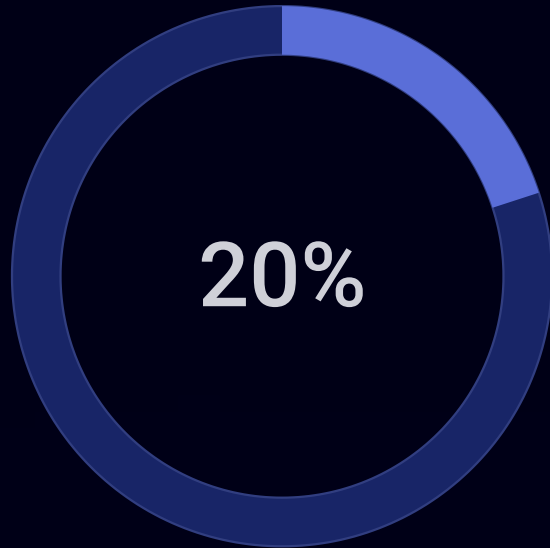
Has required > 3 Hotfixes or Engineering Interruptions in Q4.

4

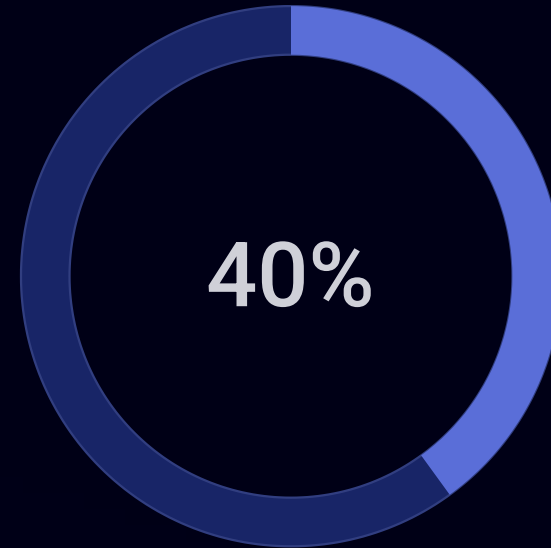
Strategic

Has not been updated in 3+ Quarters.

Subtraction is Multiplicative.



Feature Surface Area Killed



Engineering Bandwidth Released

The ROI: Deleting a Zombie feature is mathematically equivalent to hiring 2 new Senior Engineers, with Zero Increase in Opex.



Delete 1 Zombie Feature



+2 Senior Engineers

The Forensic Audit.

Action: Map every epic in your codebase to a P&L Line Item.

Tagging: Label features as:

Driver

Drives Revenue/Retention.

(Keep/optimize)

Utility

Necessary boring infrastructure.

(Minimize cost)

Zombie

Low usage, High cost.

(KILL)

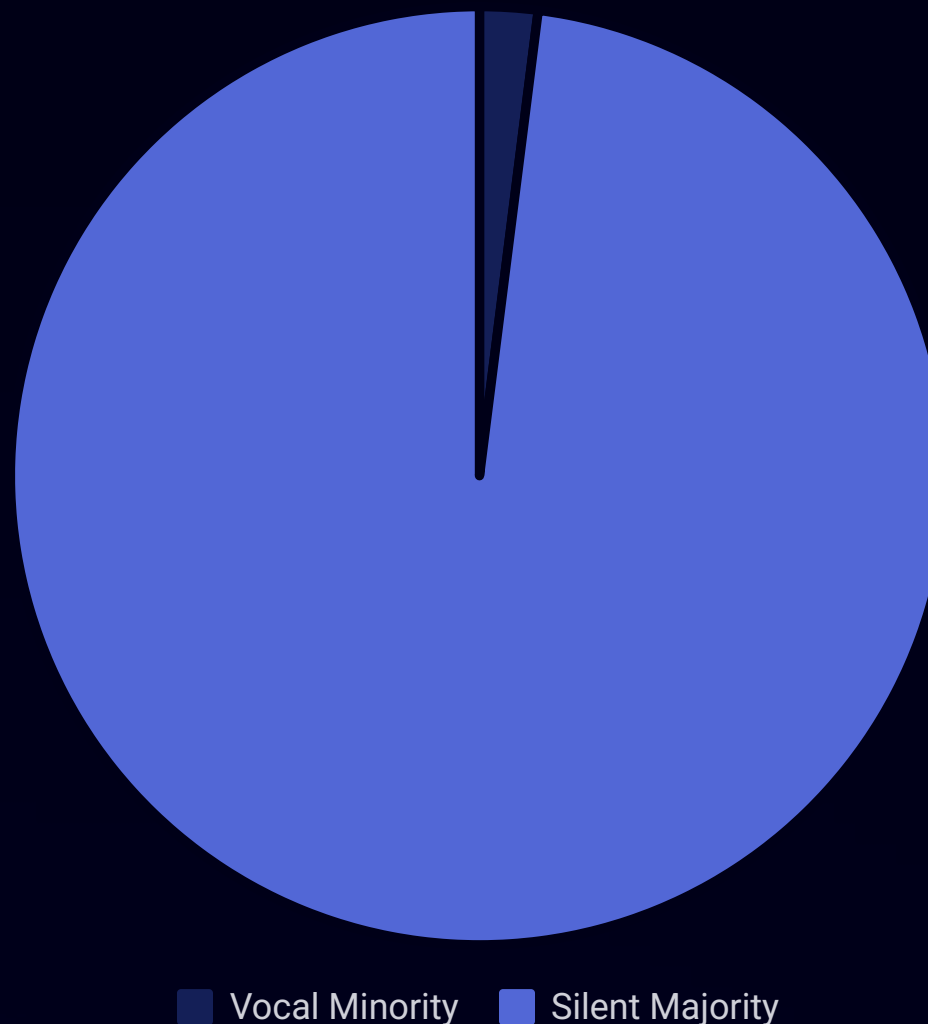
Managing the Scream Test.

The Fear

"What if a customer screams?"

The Tactics

- **30-Day Notice:** Inform users of deprecation via in-app banner.
- **The "Vocal Minority" Rule:** If only 2% of users complain, the decision was correct. Do not let 2% of users hold 98% of your roadmap hostage.



This chart illustrates the "Vocal Minority" Rule, emphasizing that a small percentage of users often voice complaints, while the vast majority remain silent. Focus on the needs of the 98% rather than letting a vocal few dictate product decisions.

Hard Deletion.



Instruction: Do not "hide" the feature. Do not "comment out" the code.



Erase the database tables



Remove the API endpoints



Reduce the surface area

Action: Reduce the surface area of the application.

The New Policy.

"Product Management is not just about what we build. It is about what we destroy."

Call to Action: Initiate the Kill Switch. Stop being a curator of a museum. Start being a manager of a High-Yield Portfolio.

Algorithmic Solvency.

The Office of the Product Economist

Services: APER Diagnostic & Turnaround Advisory.

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